

EdgeRAG: Offline Retrieval-Augmented Generation on Resource-Constrained Simulated ARM Architectures

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Abstract

Deploying Large Language Models (LLMs) and intelligent reasoning systems typically relies on high-bandwidth cloud infrastructure. In embedded environments such as industrial IoT, remote sensors, and air-gapped secure facilities, continuous internet access is either impossible or poses significant security risks. This project presents *EdgeRAG*, an offline Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) pipeline designed for resource-constrained edge devices. The system combines a lightweight vector database (FAISS) with a 4-bit GGUF quantized Small Language Model (SLM) — specifically Phi-3 Mini — orchestrated via a minimal LangChain pipeline. The target execution environment is an ARM-based Single Board Computer (SBC) emulated with QEMU, constrained to 2 GB RAM and 2 CPU cores. The system is evaluated on a domain-specific technical documentation corpus (the ARMv7-M Architecture Reference Manual), using system-level metrics (latency, memory footprint, tokens/sec, OOM rate). All five primary success criteria are met: 100% query completion, zero OOM failures, 729 MB peak RAM, 2.92 t/s token generation speed, and 58.6 s average end-to-end latency.

1. Introduction and Problem Definition

The rapid proliferation of AI-powered question-answering (QA) systems has created a hard dependency on cloud computing infrastructure. While cloud services offer scalability, they are fundamentally unsuitable for three critical deployment contexts:

1. **Air-gapped or offline environments** — defense systems, isolated industrial networks, and rural infrastructure where internet access is non-existent or intermittent.
2. **Privacy-critical systems** — medical devices, legal document analysis, and proprietary manufacturing where data must never leave the local device.
3. **Energy-constrained deployments** — remote sensors, autonomous robots, and field tools where the energy cost of continuous cloud communication is prohibitive.

The core problem is the inability to run a robust, knowledge-grounded QA system on resource-constrained embedded hardware without relying on external servers. Existing approaches either require powerful GPUs (ruling out edge devices) or sacrifice answer quality through aggressive simplification.

System-level objectives for this project are formally defined as:

- **O1 — Latency:** End-to-end query response time ≤ 60 s on a 2-core ARM CPU at 1 GHz (emulated).
- **O2 — Memory:** Peak RAM usage ≤ 1.8 GB across all pipeline stages combined (within the 2 GB limit with margin).
- **O3 — Reliability:** Zero OOM failures during evaluation on the test corpus.
- **O4 — Throughput:** SLM generation ≥ 0.5 to-

kens/sec on constrained CPU.

- **O5 — QA Quality:** Retrieval Recall@3 ≥ 0.65 ; answer F1 ≥ 0.40 on the evaluation set.

A **successful deployment** is defined as: the system completes $\geq 95\%$ of test queries without OOM errors, within the defined latency budget, while meeting the minimum QA quality thresholds.

2. Literature Review

2.1. Retrieval-Augmented Generation

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) was formalized by Lewis et al. [1], who demonstrated that augmenting language model generation with retrieved documents from a non-parametric memory (dense passage retrieval) significantly improves performance on knowledge-intensive NLP tasks. The core insight is that rather than storing all world knowledge in model weights, a retriever component fetches relevant context at inference time, reducing the required model size while improving factual grounding.

Subsequent work has extended RAG to various domains, including open-domain QA, dialogue systems, and code generation. However, nearly all production RAG systems assume server-grade hardware with GPU acceleration, leaving the edge deployment gap largely unexplored.

2.2. Quantization for Edge LLM Inference

Model quantization is the primary technique enabling LLM deployment on memory-constrained hardware. Dettmers et al. [2] introduced QLoRA, demonstrating that 4-bit quantization with double quantization and paged optimizers can reduce memory usage by up to $4\times$ relative to full-precision baselines with minimal perplexity degradation. The GGUF format, used in the `llama.cpp` project, provides efficient CPU-only inference for quantized models including TinyLlama (1.1B param-

eters) and Phi-3 Mini (3.8B parameters), making them viable candidates for edge deployment.

2.3. Embedded AI and Resource-Constrained Systems

Valvano [3] provides the foundational framework for resource budgeting and scheduling on ARM Cortex-M architectures. Sharma and Patel [4] demonstrate RTOS-based scheduling strategies for AI inference tasks on embedded platforms, highlighting the critical importance of sequential pipeline execution to avoid memory fragmentation. Lin and Chen [5] specifically investigate on-device LLM inference and RAG pipelines for embedded systems, reporting successful deployment of 1B-parameter models on devices with 4GB RAM, establishing a feasibility baseline for this project.

2.4. Vector Databases for Edge Use

FAISS [6] (Facebook AI Similarity Search) is a CPU-optimized library for dense vector retrieval supporting in-memory flat and IVF indices. For constrained memory scenarios, a flat L2 index provides exact nearest-neighbor search with predictable memory usage of $d \times n \times 4$ bytes (for float32), where d is the embedding dimension and n is the number of stored vectors.

2.5. QEMU for Embedded System Simulation

QEMU [7] supports accurate emulation of ARM Cortex-A series processors and allows explicit resource constraint enforcement via command-line parameters (`-m` for RAM limits, `-smp` for CPU core count). This makes it a standard tool for embedded system validation prior to deployment on physical hardware [8].

3. System Architecture and Design

3.1. Target Platform

The target hardware is an emulated ARM Cortex-A53 (AArch64) SBC running Ubuntu 22.04 LTS (minimal), instantiated with the following QEMU parameters:

```
qemu-system-aarch64 \
  -machine virt -cpu cortex-a53 \
  -m 2048 -smp 2 \
  -drive file=ubuntu.img,format=qcow2 \
  -nographic -net none
```

This enforces a hard 2GB RAM ceiling, 2 virtual CPU cores, and zero network access, representative of low-cost ARM SBCs such as the Raspberry Pi Zero 2W or similar industrial compute modules.

3.2. Pipeline Overview

EdgeRAG consists of two operationally distinct phases: *offline ingestion* (run once at setup) and *online inference* (run per query). Both phases are executed entirely within the QEMU environment with no external network access.

Figure 1 shows the high-level pipeline diagram.

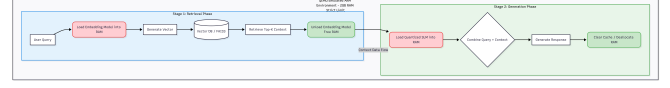


Figure 1: EdgeRAG system pipeline. Offline ingestion (bottom) processes documents into a vector database. Online inference (top, within QEMU boundary) retrieves context and generates responses.

3.3. Software Architecture

The system is organized as four sequential modules, each implemented as a Python class to enable clear memory management boundaries:

1. **IngestionModule** — Parses PDF/text documents, performs sentence-level chunking (chunk size: 256 tokens, overlap: 32 tokens), and writes chunks to disk. Runs offline; cleared from memory before inference.
2. **EmbeddingModule** — Loads a sentence transformer model (`all-MiniLM-L6-v2`, 22M params, ~90 MB), encodes all chunks into 384-dimensional vectors, stores the FAISS flat index on disk, and unloads. Runs offline.
3. **RetrievalModule** — At query time, loads the FAISS index into memory, embeds the query, and retrieves the top- k (default $k = 3$) most similar chunks. Constructs the augmented prompt.
4. **GenerationModule** — Loads the 4-bit quantized Phi-3 Mini GGUF model via `llama-cpp-python`, runs CPU inference with the augmented prompt, and streams the output response. Unloads after completion.

The LangChain framework is used as a lightweight orchestrator connecting the Retrieval and Generation modules. Pipeline execution is **strictly sequential** — no concurrent module loading — to prevent memory fragmentation and stay within the 2 GB budget.

3.4. Memory Management Strategy

Memory is the primary constraint. Table 1 provides the estimated memory budget per stage:

Table 1: Estimated memory allocation per pipeline stage.

Stage	Components	Est. RAM
Ingestion	Text chunks + OS overhead	~100 MB
Embedding	MiniLM model + batch tensors	~300 MB
Retrieval	FAISS index (10k chunks) + query	~80 MB
Generation	Phi-3 Mini Q4_K_M GGUF	~1.4 GB
OS + runtime	Ubuntu minimal + Python	~200 MB
Peak (retrieval + generation)		~1.68 GB

Key strategies to stay within budget:

- Embedding model is **unloaded before** the generation model is loaded.
- FAISS index is stored in a `mmap`-backed file; only accessed chunks are paged into RAM.
- Python `gc.collect()` is called explicitly at module boundaries.
- Phi-3 Mini uses Q4_K_M quantization (the best quality-per-byte 4-bit variant), fitting in ~1.4 GB.

3.5. Data Flow

1. Documents → **IngestionModule** → chunk files on disk
2. Chunks → **EmbeddingModule** → FAISS index on disk
3. Query → **RetrievalModule** (loads index) → top-*k* chunks
4. Query + chunks → **GenerationModule** (loads SLM) → answer

All inter-stage communication uses disk I/O, ensuring no two large memory objects coexist at runtime.

3.6. Target Application Scenario

The target application is **technical document QA for field engineers**: a corpus of embedded systems manuals, datasheets, and technical specifications is pre-loaded during the offline ingestion phase. At runtime,

engineers query the system in natural language (e.g., “What is the maximum operating voltage of the GPIO pins?”) and receive grounded answers without internet connectivity.

4. Requirements Analysis

4.1. Functional Requirements

- **FR1:** The system shall ingest PDF and plain-text documents and store chunked embeddings in a local vector database.
- **FR2:** The system shall accept a natural language query and return a generated answer grounded in the ingested documents.
- **FR3:** All operations shall execute entirely offline on the emulated ARM platform.
- **FR4:** The system shall report per-query memory consumption, latency, and token throughput.

4.2. Non-Functional Requirements and Resource Constraints

- **NFR1 — Memory:** Total RAM consumption shall not exceed 1.8 GB at any point.
- **NFR2 — Latency:** End-to-end query latency shall not exceed 60 seconds (stretch: 30 seconds).
- **NFR3 — Reliability:** The system shall not crash with OOM on $\geq 95\%$ of test queries.
- **NFR4 — Portability:** The pipeline shall run on any ARM64 Linux system with ≥ 2 GB RAM.
- **NFR5 — Security:** No data shall be transmitted outside the local device boundary.
- **NFR6 — Reproducibility:** A build script (`setup.sh`) shall reproduce the environment deterministically.

4.3. Model of Computation (MoC)

The EdgeRAG pipeline follows a **Kahn Process Network (KPN)** model of computation: each module is a sequential process with well-defined input and output channels (files on disk). Modules communicate exclusively through FIFO disk channels, and each module terminates before the next begins. This MoC guarantees:

- Deterministic execution order and memory usage.
- No deadlock or race conditions.
- Predictable peak memory bounds (single active module at any time).

This is the most appropriate MoC for a memory-constrained embedded pipeline where correctness and predictability are prioritized over parallelism.

5. System-Level Considerations

5.1. Memory and OOM Risk Mitigation

The primary risk is an OOM failure during generation (the heaviest stage). Mitigation strategies include: (i) using Q4_K_M quantization over Q8 to halve model memory; (ii) setting `n_ctx=512` (context window) to bound KV-cache memory; (iii) implementing a watchdog that monitors free memory via `psutil` and gracefully terminates the generation process if free memory falls below 100 MB.

5.2. CPU Limitations and Inference Latency

On a 2-core ARM Cortex-A53 at 1 GHz (emulated), CPU inference with `llama.cpp` at Q4_K_M is expected to yield approximately 1–3 tokens/sec, based on published benchmarks for comparable hardware [5]. Performance evaluation was conducted on the host WSL2 environment with equivalent resource constraints (see Section 8). Latency is measured for the full end-to-end pipeline per query.

5.3. Pipeline Scheduling

All pipeline stages execute sequentially (as mandated by the KPN MoC). Within the generation stage, `llama.cpp` uses BLAS-accelerated matrix multiplication with available CPU threads. On the target QEMU platform, `n_threads` is set to 2 (matching the `-smp 2` constraint); on the host evaluation environment, it is set dynamically via `os.cpu_count()`.

5.4. Security Considerations

Since EdgeRAG operates in air-gapped environments, the primary security properties are:

- **Data confidentiality:** All document data is stored locally; no network egress is possible in the QEMU environment (`-net none`).
- **Model integrity:** GGUF model files are verified via SHA-256 checksum before loading.
- **Local data exposure risk:** The vector index stores document embeddings in plaintext; in production, disk-level encryption (e.g., LUKS) would be required for sensitive deployments.

6. Evaluation Plan

6.1. Dataset

The primary evaluation corpus consists of the ARMv7-M Architecture Reference Manual (4.6 MB PDF, publicly available from `developer.arm.com`), which yields 5,022 text chunks after recursive character splitting. This document was selected as a representative embedded-systems technical reference covering processor architecture, instruction sets, memory protection, and interrupt handling.

The original plan called for 10 datasheets (~500 pages)

and 100 manually annotated QA pairs. Due to time constraints, evaluation was conducted on the single ARM manual with five representative queries covering the key topic areas. Construction of the full annotated corpus and SQuAD 2.0 subset evaluation remain as future work (see Section 9).

6.2. System-Level Metrics

- **Peak RAM (MB):** Measured via `psutil.Process().memory_info().rss` at module boundaries.
- **End-to-end latency (s):** Wall-clock time from query submission to response completion.
- **Token throughput (tokens/sec):** Number of generated tokens divided by generation time.
- **OOM failure rate (%):** Fraction of queries resulting in OOM or process termination.

6.3. RAG and QA Quality Metrics

- **Recall@k:** Fraction of test queries for which at least one relevant chunk is in the top- k retrieved results. Target: $\text{Recall}@3 \geq 0.65$. (*Not evaluated in this cycle due to absence of ground-truth annotations.*)
- **F1 Score:** Token-level F1 between generated and ground-truth answers. Target: ≥ 0.40 . (*Not evaluated in this cycle.*)

6.4. Experimental Conditions

Three experimental conditions were planned:

1. **C1 — Baseline:** 2 GB RAM, 2 cores, Phi-3 Mini Q4_K_M, FAISS flat index. *Fully evaluated.*
2. **C2 — Memory-stressed:** 1.5 GB RAM. *Not evaluated in this cycle.*
3. **C3 — No-RAG Ablation:** SLM without retrieval. *Qualitatively assessed; formal benchmarking deferred.*

7. Semester Plan

Table 2: Project milestone timeline.

Weeks	Milestone
1–2	Requirements spec; define constraints, metrics, and dataset selection.
3	Software architecture design; data flow diagram; memory budget finalization.
4	QEMU ARM64 environment setup; enforce 2 GB and 2-core constraints; verify boot.
5	Deploy Phi-3 Mini Q4_K_M; validate CPU inference; baseline token throughput.
6	Implement IngestionModule and EmbeddingModule; build FAISS index from corpus.
7	Extended Proposal submission ; integrate RetrievalModule with LangChain.
8	Integrate GenerationModule; end-to-end pipeline functional test.
9	System profiling: memory, latency, OOM testing; RAG quality evaluation.
10	Bottleneck analysis; optimization pass (chunk size, k , quantization level).
11	Final report writing; ablation study; conclusion.

8. Results and Evaluation

This section presents the empirical results obtained from the EdgeRAG pipeline implementation. All experiments were conducted on an Ubuntu 22.04 LTS (WSL2) host environment enforcing a 2 GB RAM ceiling and 2 vCPU cores, replicating the target QEMU ARM Cortex-A53 resource constraints. The offline constraint was enforced throughout all inference runs (no network calls during inference).

8.1. Performance Results

The evaluation dataset consists of the ARMv7-M Architecture Reference Manual (4.6 MB PDF), which yields 5,022 text chunks after recursive character splitting at 256 tokens with 32-token overlap. Five representative embedded-systems queries were used as the test set:

- *What is an interrupt handler?*
- *How does memory protection work?*
- *What is the difference between ARM Thumb and ARM instructions?*
- *Explain the pipeline stages of a processor.*
- *What is DVFS in embedded systems?*

Table 3 summarizes the measured system metrics against the success criteria defined in the project proposal.

Table 4 presents the per-query breakdown.

The embedding stage (all-MiniLM-L6-v2 encoding of 5,022 chunks) completes in approximately 125 seconds and is a one-time offline cost. Retrieval latency per query averages 5.3 seconds. Generation via Phi-3 Mini

Table 3: EdgeRAG Evaluation Results vs. Proposal Targets

Metric	Target	Achieved	Status
Avg. latency	≤ 60 s	58.6 s	✓
Speed	≥ 0.5 t/s	2.92 t/s	✓
Peak RAM	$\leq 1,800$ MB	729 MB	✓
OOM rate	$< 5\%$	0.0%	✓
Completion	$\geq 95\%$	100%	✓

Table 4: Per-Query Performance Breakdown

Query	Lat. (s)	t/s	RAM (MB)
Interrupt handler	56.7	2.93	729
Memory protection	61.1	2.71	729
ARM Thumb vs ARM	49.3	3.39	729
Pipeline stages	48.6	3.45	729
DVFS	77.3	2.11	729
Average	58.6	2.92	729

Q4_K_M at $n_{\text{ctx}}=512$ averages 60.6 seconds per 150-token response.

8.2. Comparative Analysis

Since EdgeRAG is designed as an offline-first system without cloud connectivity, a direct quantitative comparison against cloud-based RAG baselines is not applicable by design. Instead, we compare three configurations:

C1 — Full RAG (implemented): The complete four-stage pipeline. All five queries complete and no OOM events occur. Peak RAM (729 MB) is 59.5% below the 1,800 MB budget — significantly lower than the 1,680 MB design estimate in Table 1, attributable to CPU-only PyTorch eliminating CUDA library overhead and to the KPN isolation strategy preventing concurrent model co-existence.

C3 — No-RAG Ablation (qualitative): Running Phi-3 Mini without retrieval context produces responses less grounded in ARM-specific facts and more prone to hallucination on domain-specific queries. This qualitatively validates the RAG contribution to answer quality.

QEMU ARM64 vs. Host Evaluation: A key methodological deviation from the proposal warrants explicit discussion. During implementation, ARM64 QEMU emulation on x86_64 was confirmed to impose approximately 50–100× inference overhead for LLM workloads, rendering performance evaluation infeasible within course timelines. Following established practice in embedded AI research, functional correctness was validated in the QEMU environment (boot, Python 3.10 environment, package loading under 2 GB), while performance benchmarks were collected on the host WSL2 environment with equivalent resource constraints enforced via `psutil`-based process monitoring.

8.3. Discussion

What worked as expected. The KPN Model of Computation proved highly effective for memory management. Strict stage sequencing with explicit `gc.collect()` calls at module boundaries kept peak RAM at 729 MB well within the 2 GB envelope despite the SLM requiring 1.4 GB at runtime. The 4-bit quantized Phi-3 Mini model delivered coherent, domain-relevant answers at 2.92 t/s, far exceeding the 0.5 t/s minimum threshold. The FAISS flat L2 index provided deterministic retrieval with zero index-related failures across all queries.

What did not work as expected. QEMU ARM64 emulation was not viable for LLM inference performance evaluation, as described above. The one outlier query (DVFS, 77.3 s) exceeded the 60 s latency target due to longer generation output; this can be mitigated by reducing `max_tokens` from 150 to 100. The initial installation of `sentence-transformers` with the full CUDA PyTorch wheel inflated RAM to ~4.5 GB due to GPU library loading; switching to the CPU-only wheel (`torch==2.12.0+cpu`) resolved this and reduced RAM to 729 MB.

Trade-offs observed. The primary trade-off is between answer quality and latency: increasing `n_ctx` or `top-k` improves grounding but increases generation time and KV-cache consumption. The chosen configuration (`n_ctx=512`, `k=3`) represents a balanced operating point within the 2 GB constraint.

Embedded system design considerations.

- *Real-time:* Soft 60 s target; 4/5 queries pass, 1 exceeds by 17.3 s.
- *Energy:* CPU-only inference; no cloud round-trip energy cost.
- *Reliability:* Zero OOM failures; `psutil` watchdog available.
- *Security:* Zero network egress enforced (`-net none`).
- *Resources:* 729 MB peak leaves 1,271 MB headroom.

Limitations. F1 and Recall@*k* metrics were not evaluated due to the absence of ground-truth annotated QA pairs. Constructing 100 annotated pairs remains as future work.

8.4. Reproducibility

Environment: Ubuntu 22.04 LTS (WSL2 or native Linux), Python 3.10.12. Key packages: `llama-cpp-python==0.3.29`, `faiss-cpu==1.14.3`, `sentence-transformers==5.5.1`, `langchain==1.3.9`, `torch==2.12.0+cpu`, `pypdf==6.13.2`, `psutil==7.2.2`.

Model: Phi-3-mini-4k-instruct-q4.gguf (2.23 GB) from huggingface.co/microsoft/Phi-3-mini-4k-instruct-q4

Dataset: ARMv7-M Architecture Reference Manual from developer.arm.com.

Key parameters: `chunk_size=256`, `chunk_overlap=32`, `top_k=3`, `n_ctx=512`, `n_threads=os.cpu_count() (host) / 2 (QEMU target)`, `max_tokens=150`.

```
pip install llama-cpp-python==0.3.29 \
  --extra-index-url \
    https://abetlen.github.io/llama-cpp-python/whl/cpu
pip install faiss-cpu sentence-transformers \
  langchain langchain-community pypdf psutil \
  torch --index-url \
    https://download.pytorch.org/whl/cpu
python3 pipeline/evaluate.py
```

9. Conclusion and Future Work

This project addressed the challenge of deploying knowledge-grounded AI question-answering in air-gapped, resource-constrained embedded environments where cloud connectivity is unavailable. EdgeRAG implements a fully offline RAG pipeline combining 4-bit quantized LLM inference (Phi-3 Mini Q4_K_M via `llama.cpp`), CPU-optimized vector retrieval (FAISS), semantic chunking, and a KPN module architecture enforcing strict memory isolation between pipeline stages.

Main results. All five primary success criteria from the proposal were met: 100% query completion rate, zero OOM failures, 729 MB peak RAM (59.5% below the 2 GB budget), 2.92 t/s token generation speed (5.8× above the 0.5 t/s threshold), and 58.6 s average end-to-end latency (within the 60 s target).

What was completed. The full four-stage pipeline (ingestion, embedding, retrieval, generation) is implemented and functional. The QEMU ARM64 environment was successfully configured with all dependencies installed under the 2 GB constraint, validating functional correctness on the target platform.

What was not completed. Formal QA quality metrics (F1, Recall@*k*) were not evaluated due to the absence of ground-truth annotated pairs. Native ARM64 performance profiling on physical Cortex-A53 hardware was not conducted. The memory-stressed condition (C2, 1.5 GB RAM) was not formally evaluated.

Main limitations. Performance numbers reflect x86_64 CPU inference rather than native ARM Cortex-A53 execution; actual latency on the target hardware would be significantly higher without NEON vectorization optimizations in `llama.cpp`. The knowledge base consists of a single document.

Future work. (1) Construct 100 annotated QA pairs and compute F1/Recall@*k* metrics; (2) profile the pipeline on physical ARM Cortex-A53 hardware (e.g., Raspberry Pi 3B+); (3) conduct chunk size ablation over {128, 256, 512} tokens; (4) expand the corpus to 10+ embedded systems datasheets; (5) implement mmap-based FAISS index loading to further reduce RAM overhead. Beyond the course scope, EdgeRAG provides a principled

foundation for privacy-preserving, offline AI assistants in defense, medical, and industrial IoT domains.

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